A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies

Bartolomé de las Casas · 1552

Source: Bartolomé de las Casas, A Brief Account of the Destruction of the Indies (1552), 1689 English translation, text via Project Gutenberg (#20321). Public domain. For student reading, spelling, capitalization and punctuation are modernized and a few archaic words are glossed in [brackets]; the wording is otherwise unchanged.

A Spanish Dominican friar who had been an early colonist, las Casas came to condemn the brutal treatment of Native peoples under the encomienda system. Writing to the Spanish Crown, he catalogued atrocities to argue for reform. His account fueled the "Black Legend" of Spanish cruelty and remains a powerful — if one-sided — window into the human cost of conquest and the Columbian Exchange.

Connect: How does las Casas's purpose — persuading the Crown to reform — shape what he chose to describe and how he described it?

Key Passages

On the peoples of the Indies

Now this infinite multitude of men are by the Creation of God innocently simple, altogether void of and averse to all manner of craft, subtlety and malice, and most obedient and loyal subjects to their native sovereigns;

On the conduct of the conquerors

The Spaniards first assaulted the innocent sheep, so qualified by the Almighty, as is mentioned above, like most cruel tigers, wolves and lions hunger-starved, … that of three millions of persons, which lived in Hispaniola itself, there is at present but the inconsiderable remnant of scarce three hundred.

On the division of the people

they divided among themselves the young men, women, and children reserved promiscuously [indiscriminately] for that purpose, one obtained thirty, another forty, to this man one hundred were disposed, … they sent the males to the mines to dig and bring away the gold, which is an intolerable labor; … the men died in mines, hunger starved and oppressed with labor, and the women perished in the fields, harassed and broken with the like evils and calamities: Thus an infinite number of inhabitants that formerly peopled this island were exterminated and dwindled away to nothing by such consumptions [wasting away].

On the motive of the Spaniards

The Spaniards first set sail to America, not for the honor of God, or as persons moved and merited thereunto by fervent zeal to the true faith, … but in truth, only stimulated and goaded on by insatiable avarice and ambition, that they might for ever domineer, command, and tyrannize over the West-Indians,

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Spanish conquest of the Caribbean and Mexico and the encomienda system forced Native peoples into labor; war, abuse, and disease caused their populations to collapse.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The Spanish Crown (Prince Philip, later Philip II) and royal officials who could reform colonial policy; the printed book soon reached readers across Europe.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	A Dominican friar and former encomienda holder turned reformer; writing to win reform, he stresses Spanish cruelty, and Native voices appear only through his account.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the encomienda system on Native populations.
2. How might las Casas's role as a friar have shaped both his message and his intended audience?
3. Why should historians read this source critically even though it defends Native peoples?